

Signal & Castle Dome DPS

February 12th & 13th, 2011

Signal Peak (4877'), Castle Dome Peak (3788')

Kofa National Wildlife Refuge, south of Quartzsite, AZ

After the Mopah and Umpah trip in mid January I had reluctantly put the DPS peak bagging behind me until fall due to the start of WTC season combined with wanting to be around to volunteer for the SCMA RCSC class I took last year. Free weekends were a nonexistent commodity for the next few months.

Until, that is, the Baldy Snow Practice I was signed up for on February 12th was canceled due to lack of snow in the Baldy Bowl. That left me with just Sunday penciled in to go to a hike in the local mountains. Hmm.

After about two minutes consideration I spammed out an email of my own to the usual suspects seeing if anyone was up for running out to Arizona to hit two particularly interesting peaks. The first was Signal, a DPS emblem peak (meaning it's the dominant one in the area) via a route that was reported to be a 5.4 requiring rope and protection. The second was Castle Dome, a third class peak with a very interesting profile visible from far away.

The ever enthusiastic Jen Blackie jumped at the offer and I had my trip.

Saturday: Signal Peak via...Kmart?

The first sign of trouble came Saturday morning.

After the usual late night drive we'd put in a good 300 miles and pulled into a nice parking area sometime after 1 am. We were alone except for a pickup truck which after blaring talk radio for about 10 minutes at 5 am took off and left us in peace.

We rolled out of our bags at dawn, remarked at the beauty of the trailhead, and started going through our morning rituals.



About 6:30 am I was sitting in the back of my Rav4 and pulled on my left boot. Then I grabbed the other one and tried to put on another left boot. On my right foot.

“Umm, Jen, we have a small problem.”

(In my defense I’d recently downsized apartments which had resulted in much of my gear going into a large pile in the middle of my new smaller living room. As I wear out my boots quite often I have a few pairs of the same model in various stages of destruction.)

After a short yet amusing interlude where I tried to see if I could manage with the extra left boot by just loosening the laces and suffering I admitted we’d have to run to town.

30 minutes later we were inside the Quartzsite dollar store (the only place in town open that early reported to have shoes) explaining to the nice lady behind the counter that while yes technically these were shoes they were also child sized and bright pink princess slip-ons and probably not usable for strenuous outdoor use.

30 minutes and 20 miles after that an amused Jen trailed after me as I charged into the only Kmart in the grand metropolis of Blythe and ran to the back of the store to grab the first pair of size 13 tennis shoes I could find.

(“Hey look! It’s Santa Clause with a meth habit!” “Matt! Stop being mean!”)

So, a few frantic hours later back we were at Palm Canyon once again getting ready to depart.



We proceeded up a well established trail and ran across a few different groups along the way who were there to see the big attraction, the only native palms in Arizona.

These palms oddly enough are jammed up in a small side canyon all by themselves.



Bonus points for how (unlike our experience with the hieroglyphs in the Superstitions) the attraction actually existed.

The official trail ended at the Palm overlook and we continued up the canyon on a less established use trail.



After scrambling over some easy boulders the canyon opened up ahead. About this time we caught sight of a red shirt wearing climber ahead of us but never made it close enough to talk to him.

We turned right and angled for an obvious canyon where we continued our climb.



We had intended to climb something called the Rusty Bailey route which was reported to be a 5.4 with some solid bolts cemented into the rock. We actually ended up doing the standard DPS "A" route as we both became distracted by a rather obvious 3rd class waterfall and were up it before deciding we'd left the canyon too soon. Ah well.





The waterfall was 3rd class but rather vertical and a good 30-40 ft. I went up slightly slower than Jen as I didn't completely trust my Kmart boots.

From here we had to bushwhack through some only slightly pokey brush and then came to the reported crux of the route which involved an easy scramble up to a bolder marked by climbing webbing and then an exposed traverse over to an obvious notch.

The traverse had footholds but there was a move at the end that was a bit airy.

We had a full rope with us and I grabbed it out of my pack only to discover I'd left my harness behind in the car.

Sigh

Obviously my advancing age (30 in a few weeks) is taking its toll.

The harness was really just for the rappel on the way back but never fear, for I know how to dulfersitz!



Pictures do not adequately express the pain this technique is capable of inflicting but that would come later.

Buuuut, speaking of pain...



These things are an evil such one rarely finds in the modern world. They grow on cholla plants, break off, and lay around the ground harmlessly until you happen to brush against them. As that point they

“jump” and bury in your skin at which point the microscopic hooks rather strenuously resist removal. You have to use a stick to get the ball off without acquiring more spikes and even then they leave behind some sharp reminders for you to pluck out. Painfully.

Both Jen and I had several encounters with these but I came off the worse by far.

My best move of the day was coming back when I inadvertently collected three of them on the back of my shoe and while climbing down a rocky section my butt came into contact with said back of shoe. I now had three cholla balls buried rather deeply in my rear end.

Jen was much nicer about not laughing than I think I might have been though she did remark that she’d never seen me that angry.

The bummer is can’t even take your righteous anger out on the bush because kicking the thing would just bury another 10 balls in your shoe.

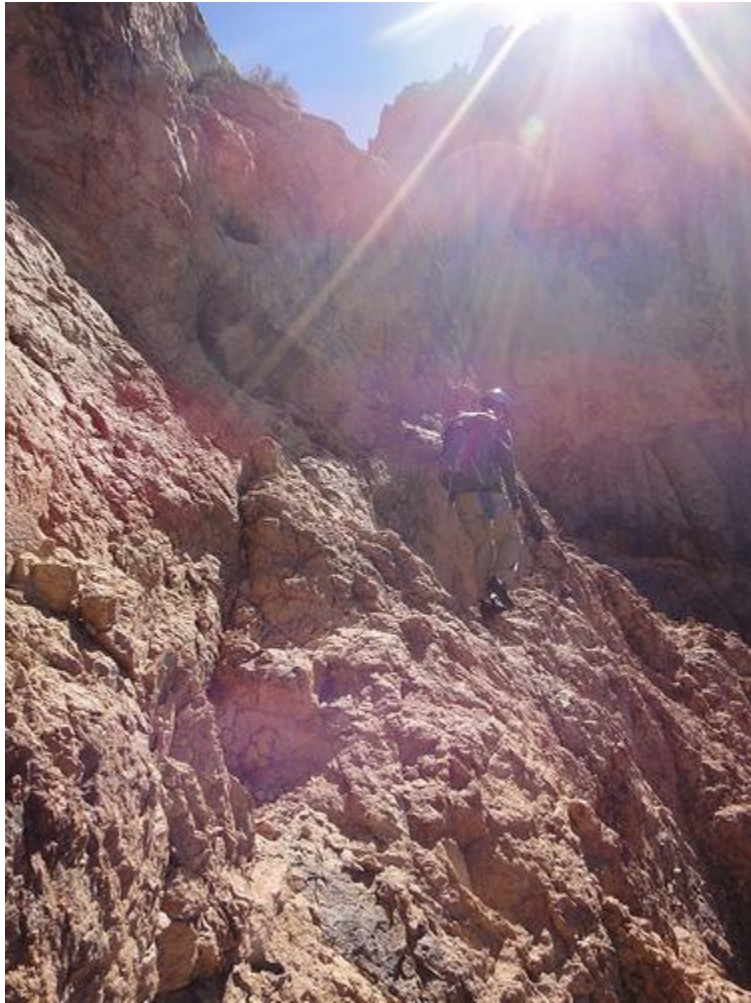
Ah, the joys of the desert.

Anyway, for the traverse I tied in with a bowline on a coil and had Jen belay me across the exposed section. The last move wasn’t bad but I was well aware of the fall and amount of skin I’d be sacrificing if I bounced down the 30 foot dry waterfall.

I belayed Jen up behind me and we took a moment to eye a rappel station already established around a large boulder that we’d be using in our eventual descent. Tracing the climbing webbing around the rock revealed it to be in somewhat less than satisfactory condition.



Fortunately I'd brought along a shiny length of climbing webbing for just that eventuality.



We had a bit of route finding after that but soon made our way up some easy if somewhat exposed rock.

After that the route became much less interesting. We skirted up some 2nd class chutes and traversing over to a ridge before making a gradual climb to the top.





The route was ducked rather clearly and we quickly concluded our summit was the uninteresting looking bump off in the near distance.



We arrived up top and found no sign of the red shirt hiker. We sprawled out and enjoyed a good 40+ minutes just taking in the view.



Being an unabashed dirt peakbagger I eyed a nearby bump that appeared to maybe be a few inches higher and promptly tromped over there just to be sure.



It wasn't.

Back on our summit we investigated the register only to find that not only had the red shirted climber not signed in but apparently Osama Bin Laden had made it up. No wonder we never found him.

		party	Country	bighorn sheep? Where?	
Greg Sobotka	2/3/10	↑	NY, NY	Nope	Ruth's www.flickr.com/photos/...
Wally Kox	2/3/10	↑	NY, NY	No	Amazing!
Dave Foote	2/4/10	5	Exeter NH	No	Great day
Jack Bennett	2/6/10	↑	OH		
Joak Vanschie	2/6/10	↑	Netherlands		
Chris Bilders	2/6/10	↑	Chandler, AZ	No	COMP 48 in AZ I will be back!
Rick Hartman	2/6/10	↑	Prescott, AZ	No	
ED FORKUS LARA LEEF	2/11/10	2	LAS VEGAS, NV	No	via Rusty Bailey route
Osama Bin Laden	2/24/10	1	Moscow, Russia, Pakistan	NO	Allah Akbar!
Samuel Munk Gabriel Munk	2/4/10	11	Texas, AZ	No	In a cloud
Weston Liles	2/24/10	↑	Yuma, AZ	NO	can't move my hand
Zach Scott	2-20-10	11	Yuma, AZ	No	From 2-11-10 and Nubby/Beel grab



There were no signs of any other climbers the entire time we were up there and eventually we decided it was time to descend.

Reversing the route was trivial until we reached the area around the belay station.



I gave Jen my webbing and she quickly reinforced the existing anchor and we set up our rappel. Normally I'd be using a harness and a device and be down in a few seconds but today I was doing it old school.



Jen's smile is no doubt triggered by my steady stream of comments regarding the joy that is the dulphersitz.



It was actually a decent length rappel and not a bad practice though I had to stop several times along the way to make sure the friction wouldn't burn through my pants. Jen followed after me using her far less painful harness and device.



The 3rd class waterfall below felt much more vertical going down but we made it without incident. Again I took greater care as I didn't trust the amount of friction offered by my \$27 Kmart shoes.

From here out it was just standard 2nd class terrain.



As we passed through the wide open area of the canyon the red shirted climber we'd seen in the distance that morning appeared behind us. He introduced himself as Nick from Tempe, an import from Maryland, and was out exploring the canyon by himself.

He had apparently tried the Rusty Bailey 5.4 route without a rope or partner, and had wisely bailed instead of risk the second and more dangerous pitch.



He was headed down also so we chatted as we went. It turned out he was a fan of mines and caves and had apparently done a fair number. This perked both Jen and I's attention.

We had to reroute slightly coming down as we swung a bit too far to the left side of the canyon and ended up looking down some 100 ft cliffs but we were soon back at the palm canyon viewing area. Here Nick split off to go see the palms up close, something Jen was decidedly not excited about



We chatted with a few other people along the trail and soon popped back out at the trailhead a bit before sunset. In addition to Nick's vehicle there were two cars were waiting for their group to return that had an easily spooked puppy Jen kept trying to befriend without luck.

Soon they left and Jen and I reclaimed the corner campsite we'd used the night before just as the sun was going down.



There was a nicely established fire ring and I'd brought wood along for a campfire. The rules of the area allow the gathering of deadwood which helped to get things burning initially and we soon had a nice fire going.





The weather was very temperate and we lasted until about 10 pm at which point both of us were drifting off.

Sunday: Castle Dome and the Unsuccessful Shortcut

Sunday's target was a good 30 miles away so not long after waking up we piled into the Matt-mobile and headed down south.



Trip reports I'd read mentioned it was rather difficult to identify the correct dirt road to take you to the trailhead but things had improved markedly since that was written. We turned off the 95 on a paved road that took us past some military proving grounds with some rather amusing signs and on to a well established dirt road



The road was public access but on either side of us was military land. One of the dangers the wilderness placards out there warn you about is the risk of finding unexploded ordinance on the ground. (Reminds me of the Boise foothills.)

The dirt road continued and eventually passed by a mine museum with a paid tour I thought might be interesting to poke through if we made it out early enough. After that the road went downhill and we gingerly crossed a wash that would have stopped any non-high clearance vehicles and unfortunately added another dent to the bottom of my Rav4. (Doh!)



We parked a bit short of the standard DPS route at the entrance to a canyon due south of our peak. We figured it was worth trying.

As it turns out there's a good reason why the official DPS route doesn't use that canyon.



The slope we needed to climb looked good from a distance but once there we found it was made of rock so crumbly it came off in our fingers. I wasn't comfortable climbing that for the hundreds of feet that would be required so we backed off.



Nothing along that slope on either side looked any more workable but to the west we could see a saddle which the map indicated would take us over to the canyon used by the standard DPS route.



This worked surprisingly well and we had a nice jaunt with no sign of anyone else ever having been up there.

After strolling down a few canyons we made it to the rather dull wash that was described on the DPS guide.



A bit further on we found where we were to leave the wash. Subtle!



The peak in the background is Castle Dome. To the left side of the peak is an easy 2nd class approach while to the right is 3rd class and listed as being rather exposed. Guess which we picked? 😊



Once we left the wash the route became much more fun. We walked up some rather pretty canyons on good solid rock and climbed a slope consisting of surprisingly good terrain (with no evil cholla balls...yet)

We took the slope right to the base of Castle Dome itself. We swung right for a time along the base as the bush became much thicker. At this point Jen cut right while I followed a somewhat overgrown path that continued left right along the base.



This quickly turned out to be somewhat questionable as I had to negotiate some painful brush but then I was able to jump into a underhang cave that looked like it would be a bit better.

I had to squeeze by in a few places as it was a bit short for me.

I popped out at the end and quickly realized I should have gone Jen's route as I was surrounded by thick brush with no option but go back or go up some rather awkward rock. Not being much for backtracking I went up.

Jen had followed my progress from her clearly ducked and almost bushless route with some amusement as I thrashed, squeezed, and made muted sounds of pain. Seeing me on rock she quickly scrambled across and joined me.

We were looking up a small steep canyon between Castle Dome itself and a small pinnacle. From where we were we could see a route had gone up there at some point but like the route I'd just taken it had obviously become a bit overgrown.



Nevertheless we decided to go for it.

The bottom had so much brush we couldn't help but lose a little blood here and there. We made it through that to find some awkward 3rd class pitches that would have been much more fun if they weren't made out of somewhat worrying chockstones.



I whacked at them a bit and decided they weren't going anywhere but still climbed gingerly.



We popped up at the top to find a plethora of my favorite ball shaped botanical hell spawn which promptly greeted me by attaching to me boot. I will say one thing for the Kmart boots; they were more resistant to spines

At this point we rejoined the route which Jen had been on below. It looked rather easier.

We swing around the SE side of Castle Dome and made our way up a fun series of exposed 3rd class ledges.



We enjoyed these so much that even the famously desert reticent Miss Blackie declared that this might be worthy of doing a second time. I almost fell off the mountain in shock!



None of the 3rd class was very difficult except avoiding clinging balls of pain and we soon approached the top.



And heard voices.

Looking up I saw someone pop their head off the summit and look down at me.



Arriving up top it turned out I knew one of them, Kevin T who I had seen at the SPS banquet a few weeks before, and another Miguel I knew by reputation. Small world!

The third person in their party, Joan, I hadn't met before.

Turns out their group, which also consisted of Wendy Conolon who was waiting below, had just done "Little" Picacho the day before. It's a striking peak we could see from there that Jack and I had done along with Paul Garry the day before that little lead fall in Joshua Tree a few months ago.



We chatted and took a summit photo together before they took off back down the 2nd class route. Despite the fact I'd sheared off a good portion of the tread on my Kmart boots Jen and I decided we wanted to go back down the ledge system, partially to climb a small pinnacle we'd passed on the way up.



Which we did.



We skipped the route between the peak and the pinnacle and followed the ducked route around the southern side.



A few times descending the ledges we had to poke around a bit to find a route that worked. I actually think these peaks would be ideal for a Sierra Club M-Rock provisional as a result.



Descending the slope below the peak went quickly as most of the rocks were rather solid and once in the wash we could speed things up a bit.

We came out at the parking spot for the normal DPS route and so had to walk another mile or two down the road to get to our vehicle.



We passed through Quartzsite, which had pretty much shut down for the day, and continued on to Blythe where we ate a quick dinner (post climb Mexican food is the best!) and continued on the 4-ish hour drive home.

So despite the minor incidents and my increasing certainty I still had cholla spines buried in my rear end the trip had gone well. We made our peaks and had an enjoyable time along the way.